

CoARA (Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment)

WUR Action Plan for the Commitments of The Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment

April 29, 2025

WUR is composed of two entities: Wageningen University (WU) and Wageningen Research (WR). Wageningen University has adopted an Academic Career Framework as a follow up to a national position paper on Recognition and Rewards of academic staff. This closely aligns with the agreement on reforming research assessment. Wageningen Research will develop its own career framework. The action plan mentions explicitly which parts of the action plan are applicable to Wageningen University and/or Wageningen Research.

Commitment 1: <i>Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research</i>

Action Plan of WUR:

The new Wageningen University Academic Career Framework (ACF) that has been implemented in March 2025* facilitates career diversification in various ways:
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Flexibility in profiles: All academics are involved in the domains of education and research, yet not everyone is expected to excel in all domains: the balance between four performance areas in the ACF (research, education, societal impact and academic services) and activities within these performance areas may differ from person to person. The choice in optional criteria allows candidates to compose a personal profile, fitting their ambitions and qualities.
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Striving for excellence: Individual academics do not need to be excellent in all performance areas but are given space to thrive in the areas that suit their talents, whilst being part of a team in which a diverse array of talents are balanced. In other words: with this room for diversity, excellence becomes something that is not only defined at an individual level but also at team level to which individuals contribute in their own unique - and excellent - way.

This commitment is also supported by the Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP) by which each research unit within a Dutch public research organisation is evaluated every six years. SEP assesses the research quality, keeping the contribution to the body of scientific knowledge central. These assessments are based on both a narrative argument and well-substantiated indicators that properly underpin the scientific achievements of the unit in the context of the national or international research field. The protocol explicitly follows the guidelines of the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA) adopted by the Universities of the Netherlands (UNL), the Royal Netherlands Academy of Arts and Sciences (KNAW), and the Dutch research Council (NWO). In line with SEP a quality assurance cycle addressing research strategy at team (chair group) level will be implemented within WU that is linked to the Academic Career Framework which allows for differentiation of functions at team level. WU uses the SEP for evaluation of research groups
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Commitment 2: *Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators*

Action Plan of WUR:

In the ACF applicable to WU, the Academic Career Guidelines describe suggestions on what sort of supporting evidence can be provided. For qualitative indicators this often takes the shape of an evidence-based narrative corroborated with examples.

In conjunction with the ACF, a research output strategy is asked for that relates to journal articles, books, proceedings and other outputs such as data sets, designs, software, etc. but that differs depending on the culture in a discipline. Within Wageningen University the guiding principles for the individual outputs within the performance area research are that:

(ii) we strive for research quality over quantity;

(iii) research output cultures are leading in recognising the quality and quantity criteria;

(iv) we acknowledge diversity in research output cultures by allowing more diverse products to be recognized;

In the ACF, less emphasis (when compared to the existing situation) is placed on quantitative criteria and the ensuing one-sided focus and work pressure, while more importance is given - though certainly not exclusively - to qualitative criteria. Quantitative and qualitative aspects of academic output are in that sense complementary to each other. For some indicators new quantitative thresholds are determined, but for most indicators levels of achievements are defined in qualitative terms in the form of examples, to be substantiated with factual evidence

Commitment 3: *Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index*

Action Plan of WUR:

WUR strives for abandoning the use of JIF and h-index. At the same time output in certain media (e.g. journals) that serve as acknowledged media for high quality outputs in a certain field can still be a relevant quality indicator.

This commitment is also supported by the Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP) where WUR is evaluated every six years. Within SEP the research unit should take into account that it is not allowed to use the Journal Impact Factor in a SEP evaluation Furthermore, it avoids the use of the h-index

Commitment 4: *Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment*

Action Plan of WUR:

WUR strives for excellence and at the same time realises that rankings provide a one sided and often not transparent view on quality. WUR supports the recommendations of a UNL report on this: Universities of the Netherlands (2022). Ranking the University. On the effect of rankings on the academic community and how to overcome them. <https://doi.org/10.17026/SS/XGDX0H>

At the same time rankings are still being used for profiling universities in an international context. WUR strives for a situation where responsible rankings on indicators are shown in a transparent way.

Commitment 5: *Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to*

Action Plan of WUR:

WU is committed to the implementation of a new Academic Career Framework, a quality assurance cycle and the Strategy Evaluation Protocol that meet CoARA requirements. This implies that also resources are being allocated to realise this. The implementation of the new Academic Career Framework is with Corporate HR (under overall responsibility of the Rector). They take responsibility for institutionalising the system and for the central process monitoring of consistent implementation. As part of this a steering group has been installed to govern implementation and budget for a project leader allocated.

Commitment 6: *Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes*

Action Plan of WUR:

Research assessment criteria, tools and processes are part of the evaluation indicators and the evaluation regulations in the Academic Career Framework applicable to WU.

After implementation of the Academic Career Framework, the experience with the framework will be closely monitored over a longer period of time, with extensive evaluations at regular intervals.

Commitment 7: *Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use*

Action Plan of WUR:

WU addressed/implemented this. The committee that prepared the ACF consisted of, among others, academic staff, and there were several consultations held in which all academic staff could participate.

Procedures and composition and training of evaluation committees have been elaborated and will be implemented from 2025 onwards.

As part of monitoring WU also participated in a national Recognition & Rewards Culture Barometer, a first measurement for WU, has been done.

The operationalisation of the ACF is interlinked with HR performance evaluation and career development (P&D cycle) and Strategic Personnel Plans.

To affect a culture change in the university's view of academic assessment in general, specific actions that guide this change are needed. For instance, specific attention is needed to replace what is often perceived as a system primarily based on quantitative indicators with a conviction that assessment is the starting point for a dialogue on career progression, with room for individual flexibility. The ACF foresees this. For timely participation in (compulsory) trainings and workshops a training programme is being developed before implementation commences.

Commitment 8: *Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition*

Action Plan of WUR:

The practices and experiences will be exchanged on various platforms such as CoARA, the Dutch Recognition & Rewards platform, SEP groups and with the Dutch universities.

Commitment 9: *Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments*

Action Plan of WUR:

All relevant documents are shared on the WUR intranet.

The implementation of the ACF is commissioned to Corporate HR.

The first experiences with the new framework will need to be closely monitored in terms of achieving its overarching objectives, and periodic evaluation moments need to be determined as part of the implementation process. The Academic Career Framework and related Academic Career Guidelines may undergo adaptations to accommodate new insights in academic practices or situations.

Commitment 10: *Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research*

Action Plan of WUR:

Open Science is also a specific aspect of SEP evaluation, and WUR supports Open Science policy via practices such as Open Access publishing, FAIR data, etc. with the leading principle: as open as possible, as closed as needed.

Open science is seen as part of doing responsible science in a transparent way. The research output strategy needed in ACF includes a strategy for Open Science. At Wageningen University & Research we aim to make scientific publications from our publicly funded research publicly available through Open Access. Additionally, Open Science at WUR encompasses a research data management policy based on FAIR data principles (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable and Reusable). Within the ACF specific focus is on defining and implementation of quality criteria for underlying research outputs such as data and models.

After implementation of the Academic Career Framework, the experience with the framework over a longer period of time will be monitored, with extensive evaluations at regular intervals.

* Recognition & Rewards at Wageningen University have been shaped into a new Academic Career Framework (ACF). This covers the reform process of the academic career assessment. The implementation started in March 2025. Details concerning the evaluation process are laid down in a – formal – document, the ACF Evaluation Regulations. Besides this the evaluation indicators document describes the indicators that can be used and provide suggestions for supporting evidence. Both the ACF Evaluation Indicators and the ACF Evaluation Regulations will be combined in user-friendly ACF Guidelines to facilitate implementation.